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STORIA

CRISTINA BATTIATO

LOVE DOESN'T TAKE AWAY SPACE

IT CREATES IT

ON THE OCCASION OF INTERNATIONAL WOMEN'S DAY, THE ACTRESS IS ON THE FRONT LINE AGAINST GENDER VIOLENCE, SPECIFICALLY ECONOMIC VIOLENCE.

"A SERIOUS FORM OF CONTROL, EVEN IF IT LEAVES NO VISIBLE BRUISES."

Text by Roselina Salemi

The other testimonials Above, Jane Fonda, 88, Oscar-winning actress and activist and, on the left, Benedetta Porcaroli, 27, star of Italian cinema. They are, together with Isabella Ferrari, protagonists of the *Pomellato for Women* campaign.

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She was Selvaggia, the bubbly girl from *Sapore di mare*, and also Flora Malva, the former diva disfigured by plastic surgery in *Parthenope*. From a Volpi Cup in Venice for *Romanzo di un giovane povero* and the Pasinetti Award for *Un giorno perfetto*, to many arthouse encounters (Mazzacurati, Ozpetek, Corsicato), and an international revival with the striking character in the film *The Great Beauty*. Isabella Ferrari's career is enviable: three children, a husband, she is radiant. Beloved by major fashion and beauty brands, today she lends her face to the Pomellato campaign against economic violence.

Is economic violence as serious as physical violence? Yes, because it acts on the same point: freedom. It is a form of control that may not leave visible bruises, but it conditions the possibility of choosing, of saying no. And financial freedom, beyond money, is independence: being able to make the best decisions for myself, without anyone controlling my choices, my life, or my need to love. That is why this is a battle that concerns dignity, and dignity is everything. No one should feel "smaller" within a relationship: love doesn't take away space, it creates it.

Do you think of yourself as an inspiration? I'm not interested in being an example. Every woman must be there when it's time to defend the rights of others. I do it for this reason.

With you are Jane Fonda, Kerry Washington, Amelia Gray... All women who don't look the other way, who don't consider certain topics private.

Who do you know? Jane Fonda, with whom I shared another campaign related to the female world. We are brought together by a conviction: freedom is not an abstract concept, it is a daily practice. Being together, today, is an act of alliance.

You have won many awards, you have acted in dramas and comedies. How do you choose your roles? By instinct. It's not easy and doesn't always coincide with what is comfortable or predictable. But when I look back, I see a path. A way, through roles, to question ourselves about who we are and who we become. There are films I didn't do, and only much later did I understand it was better that way. Sometimes you say "no" and you realize later that that "no" protected you, or kept you true to yourself. I have also made choices in life, at certain moments: I have given up projects, yet I have no regrets. Because for me, freedom, even in work, is being able to choose without having to accept anything for fear of losing an opportunity.

You are still beautiful. What is your relationship with time? I think beauty is built through self-care—of the body and the soul. It is fundamental to seek inner joy without suffering from comparison with others. To girls today I would say: cultivate your freedom and look at the horizon. The phone screen makes you believe your value depends on an image. I have a very concrete relationship with time. I didn't jump on the train of aesthetic transformations, and this has allowed me to stay true to my face and my story. Time changes the way you look at yourself: with more indulgence, more truth, more freedom.

At 50 you said you felt a bit lost. What has changed? That I am 60! (*Laughs*). At 50 I was too young for certain roles and too old for others. Today there is more space. We are accepting the idea that a woman doesn't stop being interesting with age. And perhaps we women, all of us, are learning not to let ourselves be erased, to not have to ask for permission.

What does March 8th represent, also in light of the Epstein files?

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It is a moment of reflection, of truth, and of anger, because certain things continue to repeat themselves. The Epstein files show brutally how power and wealth allow some men to abuse young women and get away with it. And they remind us that violence is linked to social, economic, and cultural dynamics.

Where do you find lightness? I have lived in Rome for 40 years, and every day in this city, for certain aspects impossible, I find the ability to make myself laugh. Lightness, for me, is this: managing not to harden, even when you see hard things. Staying curious, alive, ironic. And then happiness, yes, is often a small thing: a walk, a real chat, a moment in which you feel at home with someone. Perhaps this too is a way of "standing on my own two feet": knowing how to find a point of balance within oneself. And, if possible, being a safe place for others: for my children, for my friends, and for anyone who needs help. Because standing next to another woman, or another person, is an act of alliance: maybe I won't solve your problems, but I can listen to you.

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BOX POMELLATO FOR WOMEN

Sabina Belli CEO of Pomellato

"When a woman loses economic freedom, she loses dignity. It is the foundation of true liberty." Words from Sabina Belli (left), promoter also this March 8th of the *Pomellato for Women* campaign, which, through a video with famous women and men, including Isabella Ferrari (see gallery on the right), cries out against economic violence.

Pomellato for Women

Financial independence is dignity

The jewelry house celebrates March 8th with a campaign denouncing economic violence. The protagonists are stars who embody its philosophy.

THE VOICES OF POMELLATO FOR WOMEN Above, the protagonists of the campaign. From top left: Amelia Gray, 24, model; Kerry Washington, 49, actress; Jane Fonda, actress and activist. Andy Díaz Hernández, 30, track and field champion; Michelle Monaghan, 49, actress; Benedetta Porcaroli, actress. Paco León, 51, actor; Isabella Ferrari; Sara Nuru, 36, entrepreneur. Angélique Gérard, 50, entrepreneur; Mayu Ishikawa, 25, captain of the Japanese women's national volleyball team.

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THAT WAY HE HAD OF STROKING THE FACE

"OF UNCLE FRANCO, THAT IS WHAT I MISS THE MOST": FOR HIS NIECE, THE MAESTRO
«WAS A GUIDE. HE RADIATED A SPECIAL LIGHT, AND HE TAUGHT ME FREEDOM»

Text by Fulvia Caprara

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The recurring word is "**GENTLENESS**," and it is no coincidence that, throughout the interview, Cristina Battiato repeats it often. Because it is the word that, better than any other, describes the bond with the Sicilian Maestro who passed away on May 21st, five years ago. A mythical, revered figure, surrounded by a spiritual aura made of culture and knowledge, Franco Battiato was to her, first and foremost, the most affectionate uncle who had given her "a privileged relationship: he had no children, you can imagine how much love...". The ellipses do not happen by chance; they correspond to moments in which the voice of a special niece—a lawyer by profession, living in Milan, nothing to do with the world of entertainment—breaks with the emotion of memories: «For me, my uncle was a guide; when he passed away, I felt the earth shake beneath my feet.»

What was Franco Battiato like as an uncle? For me, he was like a father; we spent a lot of time together, I remember everything. He wasn't very physical with his affection—he wasn't one for kisses and hugs—he had his own way of stroking your face that I miss very much. He taught things without "teaching" them; he explained everything through his way of being and living, with a particular delicacy, without imposing, yet succeeding in making you absorb what he was saying.

Did he ever give you advice? He started talking to me about empowerment when I was 18-19 years old; he repeated that I had to be a free person, free from any kind of conditioning—familial or otherwise—and that I should always do what I felt like doing. I am trying, even if it's not always easy to succeed. Every now and then, when I feel something is blocking me, I find myself saying to myself: «No, he wouldn't have wanted me like this,» and then I change direction.

You have three children: did they spend time with their uncle? Yes. They are 16, 13, and 4 years old. The youngest was born three weeks after his passing and is

named after him. The eldest knew him very well and they had a stable relationship; the middle child less so because when my uncle fell ill, he was 6 years old. But they were both close to him until the very last day: my uncle lived through his illness with great dignity.

Uncle Franco was at your wedding. What do you remember about that day? I remember he was there just for me, as an uncle and nothing else, stripped of any other role. I remember the moment he entered the room where I had just finished getting dressed—oh dear, I feel like crying now—and he looked at me with eyes full of love and pride. He had followed everything; he had taken care of the musical part in the church and wanted his pianist there: a beautiful gift.

Which of your uncle's songs do you prefer? There are so many, and I often change my mind because it depends on the moment of life I'm going through. In my heart, there is above all...

"They ask me if we are related, I deny it: I protect myself from self-serving friendships"

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... *L'ombra della luce*; every time I hear it, it's like a plunge. And I am also very attached to *Torneremo ancora*; it's the last song he recorded, and you can hear that his voice is more delicate. I am very tied to that track, both for the message and because it belongs to that period of his life.

His is not just any surname. Has it ever been a burden to pronounce it? No, it has always been a great privilege, a source of pride, never a burden. But I cannot deny that it is a very well-known surname and that we, in the family, are very reserved. In short, for many years, when I introduced myself and they immediately asked if there was a kinship, I would say no, there was no relationship. It was also an attempt to protect myself from curiosity and self-serving friendships.

You decided to pursue a profession that has nothing to do with your uncle. How did that go? I am a lawyer, it's true; I chose a completely different world, I think that's only right. Genius cannot be replicated. My uncle wasn't just a singer; he was interested in all the arts, and he did so with passion, firmness, and maximum professionalism. If I had chosen to do something in his fields of interest, I would have been just a very bad copy.

Have you ever wondered why Franco Battiato inspired such a true cult following, transcending the limits of entertainment? My uncle was an extremely peaceful, quiet man; he radiated a kind of light, he had a great gentleness and a very clear vision of the universe, combined with a devastating intentness—a characteristic that went right through you. People who want to receive were literally pierced by him. When he went on stage for a concert, even if he remained silent and still, he unleashed incredible energy, and this happened among people of all ages, from 18 to 70. It's as if he managed to bridge eras and break down barriers. On the other hand, if kids today listened to his experimental electronic music, they would think it was written now.

The spiritual dimension, which was very marked in him, would lead one to think of a certain distance from earthly things. My uncle's whole life revolved around spirituality. He didn't marry, he didn't have children by choice; he needed to study and evolve spiritually. For him, the passage on earth was just a transition. My uncle had decided to strip himself of everything perceived as material to dedicate himself to the evolution of his soul. I hope he succeeded. All this without ever needing to show off anything, with simplicity.

Were there moments when he seemed distant, elsewhere? He meditated twice a day, at dawn and sunset, and those were sacred appointments, impossible to jump. Aside from those private moments, he never had any desire to show anything; it was all interiorized. For this reason, he didn't like being called "Maestro." He used to say: «I don't teach anything to anyone.»

How important was Sicily in your two lives? For every islander, the pull is very strong, and it was for him too. It's as if, at a certain point, the land you come from calls you back. I grew up in a family that moved to Milan and loved it very much; my grandmother would never have gone back to live in Sicily. My uncle developed his expressive side largely in Milan. But then the need for contact with nature, the call of Etna, of the mountain that breathes, of the scents, of the orange blossoms... Well, there comes a moment when they impose themselves. My uncle was very tied to the colors of nature, to the blooming of a flower; these were things that attracted him strongly and that, at a certain point, made him feel the need to return.

Do you feel the pull too? Yes, I am also very attached to Sicily; since I was born, I have spent my vacations there. It is my place of the heart.

If you had to summarize the story between you two, your uncle Franco and his niece Cristina, in one image, what would come to mind? The way he would look at me—a way that I have never found again, full of pure love. And then the complicity, which between us was very strong. Sometimes it happened that we were in the middle of people; something would happen that he liked very much, because he was likeable and sociable, and maybe someone said something that made him smile. Then he would look at me and, even if we weren't close in that moment, we knew

perfectly well, both of us, that we had understood each other instantly—that we were laughing at the same thing.

Photo Above, Battiato and Cristina as a child. On the right, the Maestro in Baghdad in 1992 and one of his paintings, Gilgamesh. Painting is an art he deepened from 1990. The exhibition "Franco Battiato. Another Life" (until April 26) at MAXXI in Rome, curated by Giorgio Calcara with Cristina Battiato and organized by C.O.R. of Alessandro Nicosia, is dedicated to him.